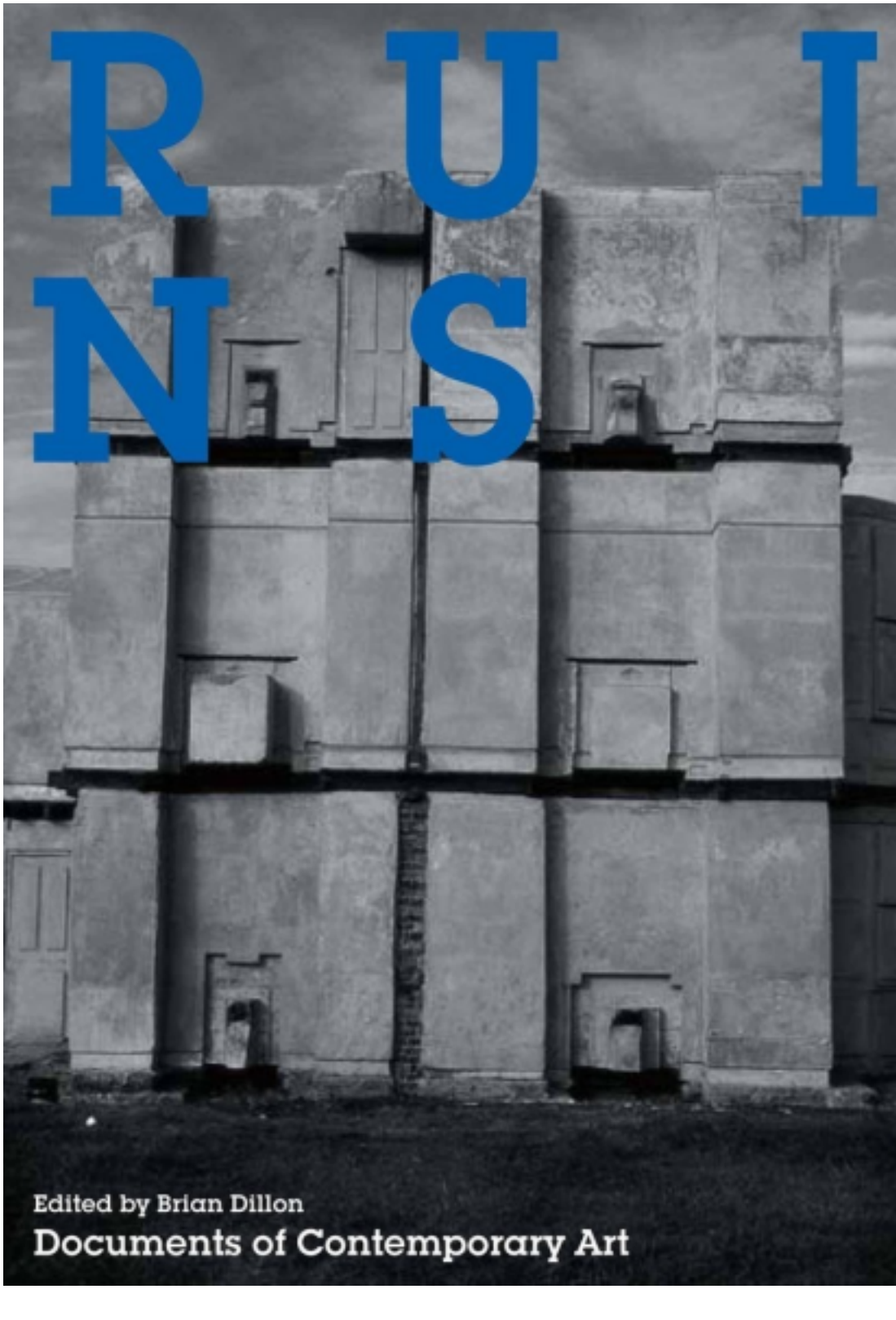
RUINS



Edited by Brian Dillon

Documents of Contemporary Art

Brian Dillon
Introduction//A Short History of Decay

We live now, though we might say that we have always lived, in a time of ruination. The first decade or so of the twenty-first century has seen what appears to be a distinct flourishing - in the realms of global events, popular culture and the work of visual artists - of images of catastrophe and decay. In the wake of the destruction of the World Trade Center in 2001, and in the midst of the wars that followed in Afghanistan and Iraq (with their images of exploded Buddhas in Bamiyan and toppled statues of Saddam Hussein, respectively) we have been faced once more with the assault on urban and architectural materiality as a symbol of geopolitical strife. At the close of the last decade, economic ruin led to a rash of images of architectural and urban-planning disaster - housing developments that would never be inhabited, office blocks that could not be completed - and a renewed awareness of the long decline of major industrial sites and cities of the last century: the plight of Detroit became the prime example. In general, a sense of the waning of the modernity and modernism of the twentieth century was in the air, alongside an awareness of the decaying machinery of colonialism and a vexed nostalgia for the aesthetic forms and iconography of the former Soviet Bloc. At the same time, the prospect of planetary ruination through climate change - a lingering disaster to replace the swift nuclear one imagined half a century ago - did not fail to nourish further ruinous fantasies and apprehensions.

Much of the art, thought and literature described in this book is a response to this contemporary state of ruinous affairs. In recent years many artists have turned to themes and imagery of decay and destruction - more especially, the remains of buildings and landscapes that now seem like relics of the last century. There has been a proliferation - particularly in photography, film and video - of work that explores (often in melancholic mode, but frequently too with a sense of still raw materiality) the ruins of modernist architecture, the defunct infrastructure of the cold war, territories decimated by industrial or environmental disaster, the relics of the economic hubris of the last decades of the twentieth century. We may think, for example, of the anachronistic dramas and reconstructions mounted by Gerard Byrne among the remains of mid-century modernism; Cyprien Gaillard's investigations of the terminal motif of the postwar housing block; Angela Ferreira's treatment of modernist fragments in colonial and post-colonial Africa; the sculptural and monumental remnants of defunct Soviet-era regimes and deposed leaders that have been filmed by Carey Young and alluded to or elaborated upon by David Maljkovic. But such works are part of a more venerable

continuum of ruin aesthetics, with its immediate precursors in artists and thinkers of the 1960s and 1970s, beyond that period in the paradoxes of modernism itself, and its more distant ancestors in the long history of ruin appreciation that is

evident in (especially) Western art from the late renaissance onwards. This book provides a survey of the contemporary state of, and justifications for, ruin aesthetics - but it looks back too to the wastelands, fragments and scenes of destruction from earlier epochs that artists have drawn on in recent years.

The anthology begins with several key texts of the early enthusiasm for ruins: a craze that culminated with the elaboration in the late eighteenth century of a Romantic aesthetics of fragmentation, failure and picturesque decline. But the main focus of the selection of extracts (from artists* writings, philosophy, urban theory and fiction, among other genres) is more recent, and the topic divides broadly into four sections. The first considers the modern ruin, and the ruin's relation to modernity. The second explores the specific role of military and industrial ruins in contemporary art, focusing in detail on the relics of the cold war. The third section is concerned with landscape and environment in the wake of the work of Robert Smithson and other artists of the 1960s and 1970s. The final section addresses the relation of the ruin to a future or futures: its capacity to invent or imagine a time to come, even as it seems to fall back into time past. Throughout the essays and passages from more extensive works excerpted here, the ruin appears in its material specificity, as an allegory for global or regional political forces, as an aesthetic trope that condenses images and ideas from different genres, as an invitation to thought and as the site of a sublime (though also sometimes comical or even kitsch) haunting.

Ruins embody a set of temporal and historical paradoxes. The ruined building is a remnant of, and portal into, the past; its decay is a concrete reminder of the passage of time. And yet by definition it survives, after a fashion: there must be a certain (perhaps indeterminate) amount of a built structure still standing for us to refer to it as a ruin and not merely as a heap of rubble. At the same time, the ruin casts us forward in time; it predicts a future in which our present w ill slump into similar disrepair or fall victim to some unforeseeable calamity. The ruin, despite its state of decay, somehow outlives us. And the cultural gaze that we turn on ruins is a way of loosening ourselves from the grip of punctual chronologies, setting ourselves adrift in time. Ruins are part of the long history of the fragment, but the ruin is a fragment w ith a future; it will live on after us despite the fact that it reminds us too of a lost wholeness or perfection.

According to the scholar and novelist Rose Macaulay, whose 1953 book *Pleasure of Ruins* is one of the classic studies of the subject, the ancient Greeks and Romans had little real aesthetic feeling for the ruin as such - but there are hints of such a

taste in wall paintings at Pompeii and Herculaneum, and of course the ultimate destiny of those cities (as of Rome) was to become themselves the inspirations for much later ruin enthusiasts.1 Though ruins feature here and there in the mediaeval imagination, it is not really until the renaissance - that is, until the advent of a modernity that conceives itself in relation to the remains of the past - that the ruin becomes an essential aesthetic concept and recurrent image in

Western art. At first ruins function merely as an allegorical backdrop, but by the time of Piranesi - whose *Prisons* and complex vistas of classical architecture invent the atmosphere of much of the ruinous art that followed - they are central to the scene: material reminders of a dead past but pointing also to the inevitable desuetude of present architectural (and more broadly cultural or political) schemes.

By the eighteenth century, a recognizable 'ruin lust' was well established in European culture. It ghosts some of the key aesthetic debates of the century - concerning the categories, for example, of the sublime, the picturesque and the gothic - and is present both in painting and in the craze for artificial ruins that is so much a part of garden and landscape design of the era. In 1770, in his *Observations on Modem Gardening*, Thomas Whately wrote: 'At the sight of a ruin, reflections on the change, the decay and the desolation before us, naturally occur; and they introduce a long succession of others, all tinctured with that melancholy which these have inspired.'2 And in 1792, in *Les Ruines, ou Meditation*

sur les revolutions des empires, the Comte de Volney hymned the sight of ruins as a sublime reminder of the passing of all human dreams and devices: 'Hail, solitary ruins! holy sepulchres and silent walls! you I invoke; to you I address my prayer. While your aspect averts, with secret terror, the vulgar regard, it excites in my heart the charm of delicious sentiments - sublime contemplations.'3

In aesthetics and art criticism, the essential formulation of this new sensibility directed at decay and fragmentation comes in Denis Diderot's *Salon of 1767* - jefore the ruin, he writes, 'we contemplate the ravages of time, and in our magination we scatter the rubble of the very buildings in which we live over the ground; in that moment solitude and silence prevail around us, we are the sole survivors of an entire nation that is no more. Such is the first tenet of the poetics of ruins.'4 This sense of having lived on too late, of having survived the collapse of past dreams of the future, is key to the ruinous optic that still animates certain artists today. It finds a particularly resonant expression in an essay of 1840 by Thomas Babington Macaulay, who predicted that in the distant future Catholicism (this in the context of an essay on the history of the papacy) 'may still exist in undiminished vigour when some traveller from New Zealand shall, in the midst of a vast solitude, take his stand on a broken arch of London Bridge to sketch the ruins of St Paul's'.5 Macaulay's New Zealander, gazing upon the wreckage of the metropolis, became a recurrent motif for many decades - the most notable example

is Gustave Dore's engraving *The New Zealander* of 1870. It is this dual valence of the ruin as image or reality, exemplified by Diderot and Macaulay - its capacity to place us at the end of a historical continuum or cast us forward into the future ruin of our own present - that traditional ruin aesthetics bequeaths to later artists and thinkers.

In 1911, in his essay The Ruin', the German sociologist Georg Simmel described

a late iteration of the ruin aesthetic of the previous two centuries - a^vision of the ruin as essentially an accommodation between nature and culture, the artificial object sliding imperceptibly towards an organic state, until in the end nature has its way and we can no longer legitimately speak of a 'ruin' at all. 'Architecture', he writes, 'is the only art in which the great struggle between the w ill of the spirit and the necessity of nature issues into real peace, in which the soul in its upward striving and nature in its gravity are held in balance.'6 In the ruin, however, nature eventually begins to have the upper hand: the 'brute, downward-dragging, corroding, crumbling power' produces a new form, 'entirely meaningful, comprehensible, differentiated.'7

Simmel's is in some ways still a Romantic conception of the ruin - it tends towards an organicism that the new century would undermine both aesthetically and historically. In particular, the ruin of the recent past becomes a telling object for many artists and writers. We may think of Walter Benjamin's *Arcades Project*, the great encyclopaedic portrait of Paris ('the capital of the nineteenth century') on which he worked until his death in 1940: a fragmentary work organized around the image of the Parisian shopping arcades that were already, in the first decades of the new century, falling into disrepair and pointing to the decay of nineteenth-century modernity and optimism. (In the late 1920s, when Benjamin was broaching the topic of the afterlife of the nineteenth century, Georges Bataille had already celebrated, in the pages of his journal *Documents*, the real and metaphoric dust that it had left behind.) Or we can consider, a decade or so later Rose Macaulay's reflection on the ruins of the recent past. W riting in the final pages of *Pleasure of Ruins* just a few years after the Second World War (during which she lost her home and library), Macaulay asks her reader to imagine a bombed out building where 'the stairway climbs up and up, undaunted, to the roofless summit where it meets the sky.'8 Can such a structure properly be considered a ruin, with all of the Romantic and even nostalgic feelings the word implies? Macaulay is ambiguous on the subject.

Modernism itself, in this period, contracts an ambiguous relationship with the ruin. In part, the urban renovations imagined by such architects as Le Corbusier depend upon a vision of the city laid waste by demolition - in a thorough fulfilment of the process begun, for example, by Baron Haussmann in

Paris in the 1860s - or even by aerial bombardment. As Anthony Vidler avers of the projected Corbusian *ville radieuse*: 'the past was either eradicated or transformed, in an eighteenth-century manner, into ruin fragments in the park. ... The city [had] become no more nor less than a cemetery of its own past.'9 In the immediate postwar period, Vidler argues, these vistas of rubble were achieved realities, and the prospect of a vastly more destructive nuclear future consequently haunts the bunker-like Brutalist architecture of, among others, Peter and Alison Smithson. And the kitsch version of this thinking had been perfected already, before the war, in Albert Speer's concept of 'ruin value', according to which the monumental architecture of Hitler's projected Germania was conceived with an eye to its future picturesque decay.

The artists whose work is discussed or excerpted in this book draw inevitably on this complex and often confused history of ruin aesthetics. But the art of recent years takes its impetus most obviously from a conjunction of artistic, literary and theoretical work produced in the late 1960s and early 1970s. The writings of Robert Smithson - especially as they pertain to and explore the industrial and infrastructural landscape of New Jersey - are exemplary in this regard. Entropy, the key concept in Smithson's work, reminds us that the ruin is always dynamic and in process, giving rise to what Smithson calls 'dialectical landscapes' that hover between the deep geological past and a catastrophic future. In September 1967, Smithson took a bus from the Port Authority terminal in Manhattan to the outskirts of the city of Passaic, where he was born, and wrote about the excursion in an essay, 'A Tour of the Monuments of Passaic, New Jersey', which he published in *Artforum* the following month.10 Among riverside detritus and the half-formed structures of a new highway, Smithson affects to have found a new 'eternal city': a terrain strewn with decayed 'monuments' to rival those of Rome. His tone is mock-erudite and ironic, but Smithson also coins a crucial term for later artists: the artefacts that he describes and photographs are not Romantic relics but 'ruins in reverse'. They are caught in a dialectical state between being built and falling into disuse and decay - Smithson's ruins make the future look old-fashioned and the past seem as if it has arrived from some unknowable time to come.

This sense of confused chronologies also marks the key literary and theoretical statements regarding the modern ruin in this period. In 1975 the French urban theorist Paul Virilio published *Bunker Archaeology*: a study of the relics of the defensive Atlantic Wall erected by the Nazis on the French coast during the Second World War. The massive concrete structures seemed to Virilio, who had discovered them as a young man at the end of the war and started photographing them a decade later, to emerge from a distant (perhaps prehistoric) past and to point to a science-fiction future.11 At the same time, they somewhat resembled the raw

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CLICHE IDEA OF INFINITY;
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OF THE UNIVERSE ARE
JUST AS PEDESTRIAN -
NOT TO SAY DREARY.
EVERYTHING ABOUT
THE SITE REMAINED
WRAPPED IN BLANDNESS
AND LITTERED WITH
SHINY CARS - ONE AFTER
ANOTHER THEY EXTENDED
INTO A SUNNY NEBULOSITY.
THE INDIFFERENT BACKS
OF THE CARS FLASHED
AND REFLECTED THE
STALE AFTERNOON SUN.
I TOOK A FEW LISTLESS,
ENTROPIC SNAPSHOTS
OF THAT LUSTROUS
MONUMENT.

Robert Smithson, *A Tour o f the M onum ents o f Passaic, New Jersey,* 1967

concrete masses of Le Corbusier's late style and the productions of later Brutalist architects in Britain and the United States. In time, the Atlantic Wall would also be explored by the English novelist J.G. Ballard, whose fictions of the 1960s and 1970s - *The Atrocity Exhibition*, *Concrete Island, High Rise* - already mined the same aesthetic of ruinous mingling of past, present and future. For Virilio and Ballard, the monumental edifices of the twentieth century - tower blocks, car parks, modernist pleasure palaces, military bunkers and silos - were already looking like dilapidated reminders of past dreams, whether utopian or totalitarian.

In the 1990s the collapse of certain aspects of the modernist dream - as perhaps best embodied in the image of the residential tower block - became explicitly a subject for visual artists. In a work such as Martha Rosler's 1993 video *How Do We Know What Home Looks Like*, the decayed and contested architecture of modernism appeared both outdated and up-for-grabs: a fading utopian inheritance that barely hung on to its (then routinely disparaged) potential for collective aspiration. Rosler's intimate exploration of Le Corbusier's Unite d'Habitation at Firminy-Vert, in south-central France, showed a dilapidated

building that had been in part redecorated by its tenants with aspirantly bourgeois wallpapers and private souvenirs, but still retained a sense of embattled technological community, typified by the radio station installed on its roof. It was, however, among artists who referred, directly or obliquely, to the end of the cold war and the collapse of the Soviet Bloc that the theme of ruin flourished in the 1990s and beyond. Tacita Dean's film *Sound Mirrors* (1999) brooded over the remains of British pre-war acoustic early-warning technology that seemed to presage the silos and satellite dishes of the cold war, while later Berlin-based films such as *Femsehturm* (2001) and *Palast* (2004) more readily reflected on the ageing or half-demolished architecture of the East. That strand of explicitly Ballardian ruin lust has continued too in certain works by Jane and Louise Wilson - notably, their treatment of Victor Pasmore's Apollo Pavilion in the postwar new town of Peterlee, in *A Free and Anonymous Monument* (2003), and their own return to the Atlantic Wall in *Sealander* (2006) - and in the vastly ambitious project of the Center for Land Use Interpretation to document (among many other types of landscape) the defunct sites and artefacts left behind by the US nuclear-weapons and space programmes in the second half of the twentieth century.

These artists and other like them drew also on cinematic precursors, both in their thematics and style. Chris Marker's *La Jetee* (1962) projects its protagonist back into the past following a nuclear war that has left Paris in ruins - the film is punctuated by images of wreckage and statuary fragments, and even the supposedly pristine past of his too-perfect memory is a museum of sorts, well stocked w ith aged mementoes. In terms of ruinous landscape or environment, cinema also provides crucial exemplars. The ruined 'Zone' of Andrei Tarkovsky's

Stalker (1979) is a model for the metaphorically productive non-places explored by such artists as Darren Almond and Adam Chodzko; the poisoned industrial hinterland that haunts the central characters of Michelangelo Antonioni's *Red Desert* (1964) is a precursor to the sites of environmental degradation studied, for example, by the Center for Land Use Interpretation. And the documentary fictions of Patrick Keiller - a tireless chronicler of the decay of English landscape and cities - have much in common with, and have been for a decade an abiding influence on, gallery-based artists. All this quite aside from such instances of futuristic ruin as Hollywood has long projected: the post-apocalyptic stock in trade of films such as *Planet of the Apes* (1968), with its vision of New York reduced to a skewed Statue of Liberty protruding from the sand.

The scope of significance of the ruin, or the idea of ruination, in contemporary art is broached first, then, by the problem of modernism - or more accurately the afterlife of modernism - outlined above. This remains a fertile area of enquiry and of making for younger artists. A project such as Roger Hiorns' *Seizure* (2008), which involved filling a flat at a modest late-modemist housing complex with bright blue copper-sulphate crystals, is a case in point. But here we see the complex timescales that such work often invokes today. Instead of merely

highlighting the present moment's distance (in political and social as well as chronological terms) from the structure and its history, *Seizure* projected visitors back into a deep geological past and into a fantasized future: a modernism remade as a bizarre science-fiction interior. In a different medium and register, the paintings of Julie Mehretu mine the architectural history of the modern metropolis to produce impossible cityscapes with ramifying geometries and dizzying perspectives: something like Piranesi's *Prisons* for the age of globalization and (in recent years) its discontents. And a film such as Runa Islam's *Empty the pond to get the fish* (2008) further complicates the common turn among contemporary artists towards an archaeology of modernism by depicting a building originally constructed for the 1958 World's Fair in Brussels and subsequently transported to Vienna to serve as the Museum of the Twentieth Century.

The political meanings that attach to the ruin are not exhausted today by the context of the aftermath of the cold war that so interested artists of the 1990s and the first years of the new century. Among the works surveyed in this book are those that address the most charged spaces and artefacts of twentieth-century European history. The sculptures and installations of Miroslaw Balka frequently make reference to the Nazi death camps - the artist grew up in a village from which almost the entire Jewish population had been deported in 1942 - in their presentation of monolithic volumes and anonymous spaces. In her film and photographic series *The J. Street Project* (2002-5) Susan Hiller

recorded the 303 thoroughfares (streets, alleyways, modest paths) in Germany that are still named after the Jewish communities that once resided, worked or traded there - the 'ruin' in question is often no more than the name itself and the memories that adhere to it or have been erased there. Ruins are often, as here, the objects of more or less ironized archives: Walid Raad, under the working name of the Atlas Group, has essayed similar studies (though in this case veiled in fiction and myth) of events and sites from the wars in Lebanon from the mid 1970s to the 1990s.

This archival impulse has also been brought to bear on diverse forms of land use and misuse, and the ruins that they have left behind. Most ambitiously, the Center for Land Use Interpretation has sought to map the ghost places of the United States: defunct missile facilities and former test sites, dead mining towns, industrial wastelands, empty housing complexes, the technological remains of the space programme. The research undertaken by CLUI is also part of a growing interest among artists and writers in derelict or degraded landscapes, and in the intrusions of nature into decayed urban settings. (Geographers have coined the term 'drosscape' for the points on the map where nature and culture meet in ruinous disarray.) In the works of writers as diverse as W.G. Sebald, Geoff Dyer and Rebecca Solnit, the places that have in recent years animated many contemporary artists are mapped and theorized.

Perhaps the most enigmatic aspect of the time of ruination is the manner in which it points towards the future rather than the past, or rather uses the ruined

resources of the past to imagine, or reimagine, the future. This is the logic already of Walter Benjamin's Theses on the Philosophy of History' - he speaks of blasting aspects of the past 'out of the continuum of history' in order to forge a new revolutionary future.12 We can see this process at work, for example, in the art of The Otolith Group, whose redeployment of the aesthetics and politics of the past is invariably oriented towards an idea of future liberation, be it imagined in the wake of the work of Chris Marker, among the ageing buildings of Le Corbusier's Chandigarh in India or the electronic music of the 1990s. According to this way of thinking and working, the ruin is a site not of melancholy or mourning but of radical potential - its fragmentary, unfinished nature is an invitation to fulfil the as yet unexplored temporality that it contains. Ruins, as many of the artists surveyed and writers and critics excerpted here suggest, are'freighted w ith possibility, even with utopian promise.

1 Rose Macaulay, *Pleasure of Ruins* (1953) (London: Thames & Hudson, 1984). 2 Thomas Whately, *Observations on Modem Gardening* (1770), quoted in Rose Macaulay, *Pleasure of Ruins,* op. cit., 29.

3 Comte de Volney, *The Ruins* (1792), English translation (London: Edwards Brown, n.d.) 10.

^//INTRODUCTION

4 Denis Diderot, 'Le Salon de 1767' (Paris, 1767); trans. John Goodman, in *Diderot on Art. II: The Salon of 1767* (New Haven and London: Yale University Press, 1995) 196-7.

5 Thomas Babington Macaulay, 'Review of Leopold von Ranke's *The Ecclesiastical and Political History of the Popes during the Sixteenth and Seventeenth Centuries,* trans. Sarah Austin', Edinburgh Review, no. 72 (October 1840) 258.

6 Georg Simmel, The Ruin' (1911 text, based on an earlier essay), in *Essays on Sociology, Philosophy and Aesthetics,* ed. Kurt H. W olff (New York: Harper & Row, 1965) 259.

7 Ibid., 261.

8 Rose Macaulay, *Pleasure of Ruins,* op. cit., 454.

9 Anthony Vidler, 'Air War and Architecture', in Julia Hell & Andreas Schonle, eds. *Ruins of Modernity* (Durham 8i London: Duke University Press, 2009) 34.

10 Robert Smithson, The Monuments of Passaic', *Artforum* (December 1967); reprinted under Smithson's full title in *Robert Smithson: The Collected Writings,* ed. Jack Flam (Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California Press, 1996) 68-74.

11 Paul Virilio, *Bunker Archaeology,* trans. George Collins (New York: Princeton Architectural Press, 1994).

12 Walter Benjamin, Theses on the Philosophy of History' (1940), in *Walter Benjamin: Illuminations,* ed. Hannah Arendt and trans. Harry Zohn (London: Fontana, 1992) 245-55.